Right from the outset, public support was the fuel that powered the Swadeshi company. Even earlier, immediately after the violence of March, there were public calls for patronage. ‘Every Swadeshi enterprise’, wrote *The Hindu*, ‘deserves the sympathy of every Indian. An infant Swadeshi enterprise must have this kind love, but an infant Swadeshi enterprise coming out of a struggle against such tremendous odds, deserves to be endowed with everything that can be called ours.’[56]

The press—especially, *The Hindu*, *Swadesamitran* and *India*—was flooded with correspondence calling for support. One ‘S.M.’, writing to *Swadesamitran*, said that the patriots would consider the imprisonment not as a punishment but as an occasion to practise austerities. Describing SSNCo as a wish-fulfilling karpaka tree for India’s economy, he called upon everyone to nurture it in the face of the British resolve (*kanganam*) to finish off the company. He also accused the railway authorities of being hand in glove with BI to crush SSNCo.[57] So did one ‘Inanpurinesan’ who rued, in a milder tone, that the government was openly suppressing the company.[58]Another correspondent argued that it was the duty of the newly founded indigenous Indian Bank to advance loans to SSNCo.[59] ‘Our only resource … lies in strengthening the hands of the infant maritime enterprise and by means of determined voluntary co-operation to achieve the success of an industry, in which England admittedly owes her supremacy to protective legislation.’[60] These commentators had a clear understanding of the protectionist policies that the British state adopted.

At the Tanjore District Conference held in June 1908, a resolution was passed stating that ‘it is the universal opinion of the public’ that officials were siding with BI and demanded that they maintain strict neutrality.[61]



In the interview with the governor, K.R. Guruswami Aiyar claimed with pride that SSNCo attracted shares by ‘simple, pure and honest Swadeshi’.[62] A comforting statement, it conceals the hostile atmosphere in which SSNCo had to mobilize share capital. As noted earlier, the original authorized